

A PUBLICATION OF

SHIFT
DISRUPTIVE EARNING

HOW TO CREATE

Winning eLearning Courses

THE ULTIMATE GUIDE TO HELP YOU CREATE WINNING
EARNING COURSES OF YOUR OWN.





TABLE OF CONTENTS

3

Chapter 1:

Make Your Courses Engaging
But Not Distracting.

17

Chapter 2:

Make Sure Your Courses are
Simple and Useful.

33

Chapter 3:

Make it Count! Make Your
Courses Relevant and
Meaningful

46

Chapter 4:

Make it Short and Sticky.

Intro



Creating **winning eLearning courses** involves more than just presenting content and crossing fingers— winning eLearning courses share notable similarities; universal traits that explain why they are effective and what makes them better than the average.

This **eBook** will help you understand the process so you can create a winning eLearning course of your own. It comes packed with simple tips and ideas on turning your content from an overwhelming mass of gray text to something that engages learners.

A green ribbon banner with a slight 3D effect, featuring a central rectangular section and pointed ends that resemble ribbon tails.

CHAPTER 1

MAKE YOUR COURSES

*Engaging but
Not Distracting*



Getting learners to focus on your material is difficult, no thanks to the onslaught of information on the web. Efficient course developers make focusing with the material easier by making it fun and engaging. Instead of fussing over interactive and flashy elements, they prioritize active learning by placing students in charge of their lessons. This is why they're able to craft winning courses that are highly engaging.

When **interactive eLearning courses get it right**, learners experience several positive outcomes. Interactivity is essential for learner success!

1.

First, **learners retain the knowledge from interactive courses at a significantly higher rate**, anywhere from 50 to 90 percent, than passive courses, which only result in a 5 to 30 percent retention rate.

2.

Learners have the opportunity to process content and apply concepts in interactive environments. They're putting their learning to use in realistic scenarios requiring them to think, interact with peers or an expert, and evaluate the outcomes based on decisions they make in the moment.

3.

Learning often occurs faster with interactive courses because learners work on higher order thinking skills like appraising, interpreting and summarizing information rather than merely labeling, memorizing or describing information.

Don'ts >>>>>

(please AVOID this!!)

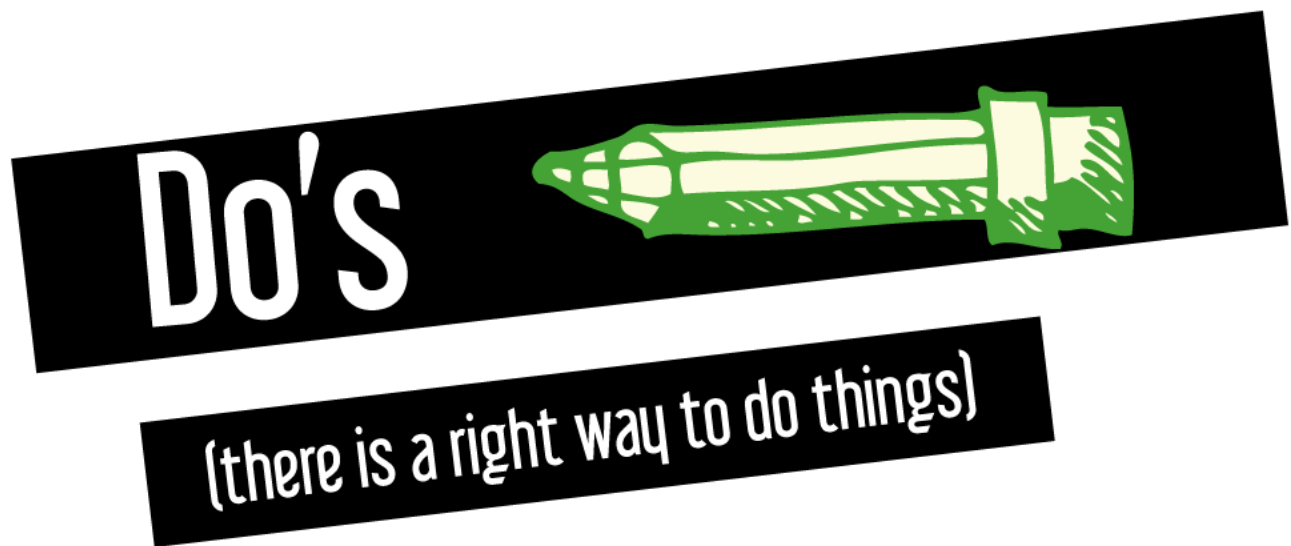
Several features of eLearning appear engaging, but actually do more harm than good, including:

Overusing unnecessary animation or sound: Bells and whistles only distract the learner and divert attention away from important content. And if the content is boring, no amount of bells or whistles will make it any better.



The "Next" button: Yes, the learner is technically interacting with the mouse and the screen, but the learner isn't interacting with the content and likely will develop clicking fatigue, waiting and searching for the next "next" button rather than paying attention to content.

Activity overload: You can't make up for a lack of interactivity through sheer volume. Too many activities on page — videos, graphs, animation, quizzes — will overload learners and could cause them to miss important content hidden amid the activities.



Engaging eLearning course must have a purpose. If the interactions are meaningless, learners will see it as pointless busy work that wastes their precious time. The key lies in learning how to balance your eLearning courses so that they are truly interactive and engaging without irritating or confusing your audience.

There are several ways to design engaging and interactive eLearning courses that increase comprehension and retention, boost learning and hold a learner's interest:



Simulations of actual circumstances where learners can play and explore with variables to change outcomes or study consequences of specific actions.

Go into action mode with an offline activity or problem they need to solve. Have learners identify problems and figure out ways to solve them.

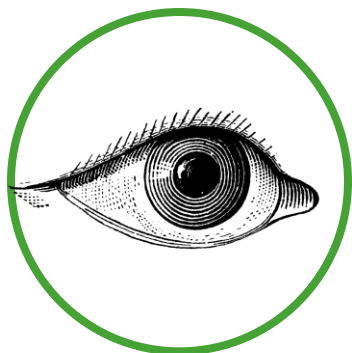
Engage a learner's emotions through **a compelling story** that guides the course, asks tough questions and requires justifying certain actions based on course concepts.

Tie interactions directly to learning outcomes and key learning points to reinforce the main content.



Make learner stop and think, this can be as simple as asking the learner a question. Good questions, an opportunity for reflection can be much more effective than pushing a Next button. For example, when you share a concept or graphic, ask learners to think about the content in the context of their jobs.

Check-up exercises where you quickly present questions to the learners to make sure they are paying attention.



Visual content boost engagement

We don't just consume visual content; visual content drives engagement in the world wide web. It's a launching point for casual conversations, even heated debates and lengthy discussions.

Visual content can help you create engaging eLearning material too.

Learners get easily attracted to visual content. A photo or video carefully chosen never fails to capture a learner's interest. It invites him or her to spend more time learning. What's more, visual content usually makes it easier for learners to focus. They tell a story, their colors delight the eyes, and they require little or no effort from users.

Be sure to use great images—those that support your learners' goals. When effectively chosen, images and videos can help students recall or retain information by as much as 65 percent. Other studies also confirmed that 40% of people will respond better to visual information than plain text.

Also, don't overwhelm your audience with having too many visual elements. **Strike a thoughtful balance between images and texts.** Too much text or only visuals may not be an effective instructional technique. Visual content should complement text and enhance learning value.

And **be creative in choosing a visual format.** Most eLearning material has only photographs, especially stock photography. Go beyond that. There are many other ways to incorporate visual content into your material. Try a short video clip, an infographic or a simple animation.

But **here's the only rule you shouldn't break:** don't use a visual element just for the sake of using one. Good images are more than just pretty visuals. They're not mere fillers or elements chosen for the sake of filling up a space. They should, instead, satisfy both aesthetic and informative requirements.

CHAPTER 2

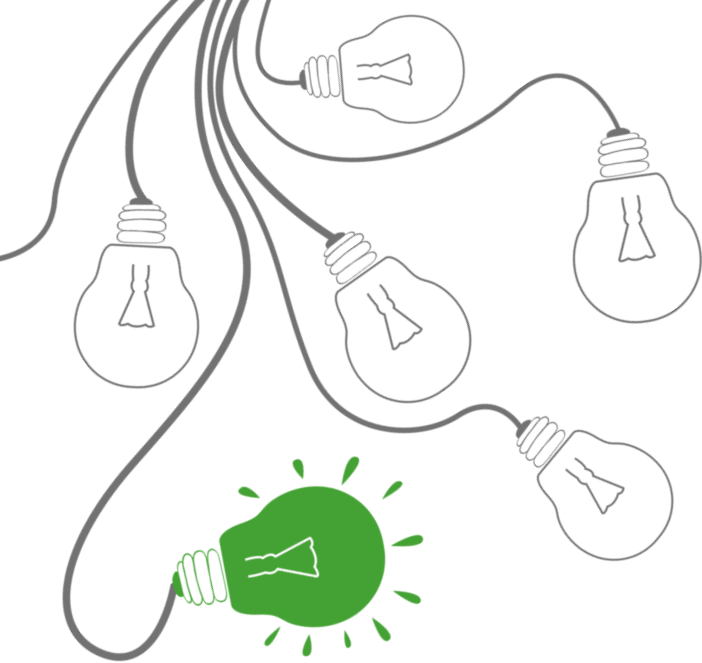
MAKE SURE YOUR COURSES ARE

Simple and Useful



Simplicity and usefulness are basic elements of the “it just works” principle. Companies like Braun and Apple, for instance, are perfect models for this. Every product they ship is easy to use users don’t need a manual to make it work.

Don’t underestimate the power of keeping things simple and useful. Instead of trying to accomplish a lot of unnecessary work and do things poorly in the end, concentrate your efforts to one or two essential stuff.



How to tell if your eLearning course is useful

Can learners achieve their goals? Learners take a course for one purpose: to achieve a goal. The degree to which they find the course useful is measured by their ability to achieve those goals.

Will learners actually find it useful



In the introductory slides or in the first few paragraphs, students should be able to answer for themselves the proverbial question: How will completing this course make my life easier?

Make them answer yes. Specify the why.

Why do they need to have a background on company products? Why do they need to learn how to avoid computer viruses? Why is acquiring basic HTML and CSS skills valuable?



Is it easy to navigate



Is navigation straight-forward?

Navigation is one of those things you must get right. Create a course that has a friendly direction, that includes the intuitive navigation people look for, and that's immediately clear to the learner what to do next. Try to keep every button simple. Use location cues so that learners can easily find their way within the course.



Will learners know they're on the right track



Does the course provide clear feedback in response to the learner's actions?

Provide a clear and prompt feedback to user actions. Have they successfully answered a question? Or finished a section? Make sure your course includes appropriate feedback functionality.



Does your material acknowledge goal completion



Is it relevant to the learner's needs/goals? Are you establishing the importance of this topic/knowledge to the learner? Do your students understand their progress? Are they aware of how much they already know?

Be sure they do by implementing quizzes, surveys and practical exercises. A group discussion or obligatory participation in forums can also help.



Is the content tailored to fit learners' real-life situations



In other words, is your content contextualized? Is it more personalized? More situational? Or easily transferable to real-life scenarios? Are you using examples to clarify concepts or theories, and those examples are relatable?

Use success stories and commentaries from people in the field. Let learners experience an authentic setting with the use of realistic dialogue and fictitious yet believable characters. Such characters should share the challenges and priorities of learners themselves.





Make it “user-friendly”

Designers who work on print and web all agree that designing is really about users—how they interact with interfaces and achieve their goals in the process.

Course developers should find ways to address user frustration issues and ways to increase user friendliness. Learners should quickly spot what they're looking for and use a button or an element without needing to think.

In short, don't let users guess, ask or puzzle over how to do things.

Here's how you can implement it in your eLearning project:

1. Use Visual Cues

Such as these

Visual cues such as bread crumbs, page or section numbers, headings, navigational bars and other signposts help learners know which part of the course they are on.

2. Make It Too Obvious

Buttons should look like buttons, links like links, and so on. It should be too obvious so that users won't waste time looking for the right element and get impatient.

3. Minimize Your Design

An uncluttered interface free of noise and distractions will make things easier for learners. Make sure to give learners enough room to breathe by using some white space. Keep your design simple. It should draw the learners to focus on the main content at hand without being distracted by irrelevant images or text. Remember, design is not decoration. Design to enhance content, not bury it.



4. Reduce Cognitive Load



Screen readers are different from readers of print. That is why he strongly advised designers and writers to cut needless words. By constantly editing and deleting unnecessary words, you make it easier for learners to grasp an idea and learn effectively.

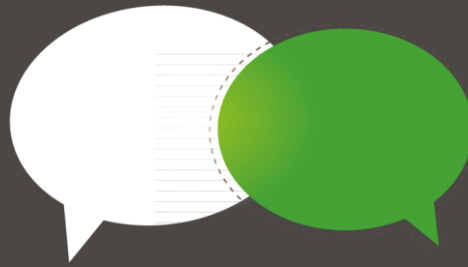
Provide learners the "must know" information (and nothing more), it reduces the amount of thinking and cognitive processing you subject them to.

Use concise and simple copy in section descriptions and summaries. Shrink lengthy paragraphs to few sentences.

5. Be Consistent

It helps to establish rules and follow them. You can, for instance, set a definite color, size and placement for every element on your course. Navigation buttons should be on the same location throughout your course. Use a different color and font type to distinguish supporting content such as sidebar information and section summaries from the main content.





6. Follow Real World Conventions

Use the language learners are already familiar with. Include words, phrases and concepts they use on a day-to-day basis. Doing so will make your material sound more natural and therefore approachable to all learners.

7. Usable Navigation



A navigation system is one of the most important elements in your course since it directly affects usability. Make yours solid, intuitive and too easy to use as to require no thought. The golden rule with proper course navigation is simple: don't require learners to think about where they need to go and how to get there

CHAPTER 3

MAKE IT COUNT! MAKE THE COURSE

Relevant and Meaningful



What's the meaning of all these? Can I apply these at work or my day-to-day living? Learners may appreciate lofty theories but they need to understand first how your course can benefit them. You have to design courses that affect how learners choose or decide on their personal or professional lives.

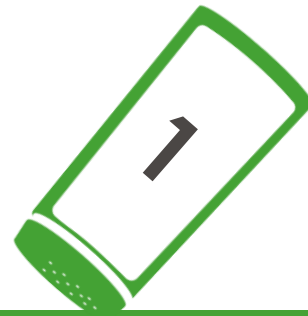
Make sure your content is relevant



Relevance has a lot to do with student-material connection. Every course should address a learner's current needs or learning gaps. Will your course resonate among students? Will they find it both useful and relevant? Make sure they answer yes to these questions before you hit publish. It is the goal of learner-centered eLearning courses to bridge the gap between what is learned and the real world.

4 ingredients to build relevant eLearning courses

(that may help you to get your learners actively engaged)



Always focus on creating **clear course objectives**:
For many students, knowing why are they there and how it will help them makes the eLearning more rewarding. Reality is most learners decide within the first few slides if the course is worth taking. So, tell them why they should care and what you'll be discussing in the course since the beginning. Give them reasons to continue.



Make your content actionable: Give learners a sense of how to apply the information. There should be a clear action goal; whatever students learn should be put to use in the job upon completion of the course. This way, the modules tell the student precisely how to use the given information.

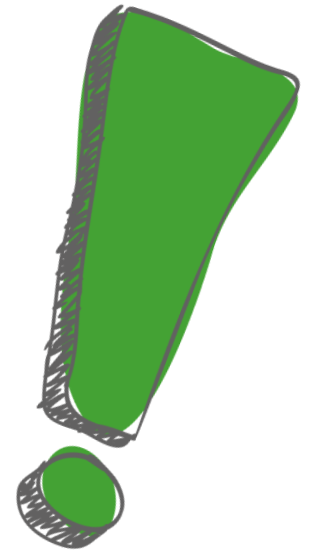


Respect the audience: Let your audience know why it's important to take a particular course. Avoid a cynical or condescending tone and honor the learners.



Simple and appealing design: eLearning courses that have an attractive and professional look are more credible and relevant to the learner. Be careful, the best content might not be read and analyzed by learners if it isn't presented simply and delightfully.

The keys to meaningful eLearning content



Meaningful eLearning modules do much more than present information to learners to consume. Instead, they actively engage the learner in meaning making. As Michael W.Allen says: "Good learning experiences aren't just about facts, they are about becoming a more proficient, capable, and valuable person."

One of the most common mistakes in eLearning course design is assuming. Course designers forget that what is common knowledge to them may be unknown territory for learners. This is a good way to make sure the learner is lost before he or she begins. For eLearning success, designers need to take a step back and change focus. The courses should to be targeted specifically to their intended audience. There is no point in creating an eLearning course if the content doesn't make sense to them. Learners immediately need to see the relevance of the material and appreciate the benefit they gain from it.

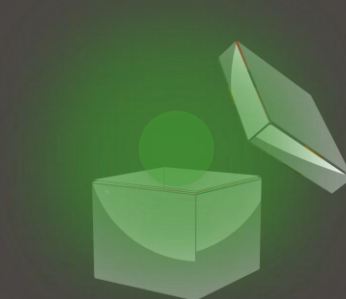
Look at the material from the student's point of view to make it have the greatest impact.

Here's how to make your courses more learner-driven, thus more meaningful. Include these 4 ingredients:

1. Challenge:

As an eLearning developer your main goal is to engage learners and challenge their understanding at all times. Challenges, without a doubt, stimulate the brain. They force the learner to think about their previous knowledge, process the new information, reflect, and then make a decision.

To include this element, focus on the question:
“What challenges will students face along the way, and what can they do after completing the course?”



2. Engagement:

Forget clicking! Engagement goes beyond clicking a mouse. Genuine engagement happens inside the brain. It's called thinking. You can easily encourage students to think by adding moments of thoughtful reflection in your program.

Make them pause for a while and ask them how the content they have just consumed relates to their work. The content has to reach them intellectually and emotionally as well. Only this kind of deep and meaningful engagement allows for lasting change to happen.



3. Personalization:

Students have different learning styles and come from diverse backgrounds. It only makes sense to make your material suitable or fit for their needs than ask them to adapt to your course.

Such adaptability has to be part of the design. Package your content in multiple formats for people to learn from – videos, graphs, charts, quizzes, activities and so on. This will help you to reach each type of learner.



4. Offer Constructive Intrinsic Feedback:

How will learners know that they are making any progress or not? By letting them see for themselves the impact of their choices. This is more effective than directly telling them if they are doing good or not.

Intrinsic or internal feedback, as opposed to external feedback given by an instructor or peer, encourages students to learn from their poor choices. It's far more motivational and meaningful because learners themselves know that they can do something to correct their mistakes or reverse the situation.



CHAPTER 4

MAKE IT STICK! MAKE IT
Short and Sticky



Make it easy for your learners is a difficult and time-consuming task. This means crafting courses that are shorter, better targeted and personalized. It's quite easy to add more content in an effort to offer everything to your students. But this is going to be futile, if not utterly useless, since learners have limited time and attention.

Respect your students' time by keeping your content concise and focused. Aim for meaningful interaction, not more information; simple yet purposeful graphics, not complicated and flashy images and videos.



Twenty minutes is usually the longest time for effective eLearning content that delivers the benefit of greater recall. It's enough time to include elements such as repetition and idea-connection and help users remember most of what they're learning.



The length of your content matters

Short and simple messages are much more effective in eLearning. Our limited working memory can easily process and retain “bite-sized” information; longer chunks are unmanageable. By thoughtfully breaking down content into bite-sized chunks or sections, learners are able to understand and absorb a concept or subject quickly. More importantly, they do not have to go through irrelevant information and waste their precious time.



Chunking, of course, isn't everything. For this technique to work, your content has to be meaningful, memorable and motivational. It has to appeal to the individual learner's goals.

Here are some tips you need to follow:

One Screen, One Concept

Some eLearning course screens look like a jumble of ideas and concepts because the course designer mistakenly presumes fancy design leads to more effective eLearning. In fact, the exact opposite is true. Each screen in a course should convey one idea and one idea only. This Rule of 1 keeps your learner focused on the most important ideas, one at time.



Set Time Limits, Not Slide Limits

Or in other words, quality over quantity. The total number of slides in a course doesn't equate to effectiveness if those slides don't contain quality material. Design a course with a time frame instead of a slide quota. Slides without a purpose will cause learners to disengage. Setting a time limit forces people to get to the point and remain focused on the learning targets.



“Show, don’t tell”

This is a simple yet elegant piece of advice given to writers and artists. eLearning course developers should take heed of this too by allowing learners to experience the course through action. This means one thing: less conversation and exposition, and more action. Instead of asking them to read paragraphs after paragraphs of raw facts, think of interesting and creative ways to impart information.

Use small learning units

Today's learners struggle with information overload. Bombard them with large data and they'll feel overwhelmed. They'll either retain scraps of information or learn nothing. Dividing information into chunks is ideal. Organize your content around digestible, bite-sized piece of information. Prioritize need-to-know and place nice-to-know information in your resources section, if needed.

A simple guide to create eLearning that sticks

For an idea to stick, it has to make people:

- Pay attention (to something unexpected)
- Understand and remember it (because it's concrete)
- Believe in it (because it's a credible idea)
- Truly care about it (or make an emotional connection with it)
- Be able to act on it (by telling it as a story)

Here are some tips to make your eLearning content stick:

1) Get Learners to Pay Attention



As a course developer, it's your job to capture learners' attention and get them engaged now. You can't afford to lose students in the **first 30 seconds** of your presentation.

There are many ways to make your audience pay attention: novelty, uncertainty, complexity, anticipation, inquiry, ease of comprehension. There are many more.

But if you are going to learn only one technique, then learn the art of getting attention in the first two minutes. Study striking headlines, catchy radio ads and irresistible copywriting. You'll find that all of them tap into human behavior to capture attention from start to finish.

2) Help Learners Understand and Remember



Students should fully understand an idea or concept first before they can remember it.

The easiest way to achieve this is by structuring your content in a brain-friendly format. The brain can process and hold only a limited number of information at once. That's why you should **divide content into bite-sized chunks and organize it** in a way that reduces mental strain.

Using vivid images or visual information is another technique to help the brain retain information. The more detailed the image, the better. You can't use visuals all the time. So be prepared to do repetitions or similar memory-retention techniques. You can repeat important concepts or key takeaways at the end of the section. Checking in with students will also help students constantly work to retain their lessons.



3) Get Students Believe

People tend to ignore ideas unless they have faith in the source. **Check if your facts and sources are updated.**

Go beyond raw facts and focus instead on creating a meaningful learning experience. Spice up your material by including credible and relevant facts, images, quotes illustrations and statistics. Testimonials and real-life stories are best in making people believe—as long as they are credible, of course.

4) Make Them Care About the Course



Give them at least one compelling reason to care about the subject. Make them forge an emotional attachment to it. **Will it make them more successful? Perhaps happier?**

The material should make them feel, think and act on something. Most importantly, the material should be about them. It should speak in their own language—that is, in a conversational, friendly tone. Use of emotive terms is okay but be careful not to overdo it.



5) Get People to Act

A well-received and well-understood speech deserves a resounding applause and even a standing ovation. In eLearning, students get and believe in your content when **action is involved**.

Tell them what to do. Allow them to perform what they learned and learn from their performance. Let them make realistic choices by providing real-world examples. Every action they take and decision they make should (closely) mirror the real world.

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